

BITTERCAKE

A 10-minute Play

By

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LOGLINE: Three generations of women—an immigrant grandmother, her calorie-counting daughter, and a vegan millennial—confront the weight of inheritance, identity, and motherhood, all through the act of baking a single buttercake.

SYNOPSIS: *Bittercake* traces one family through their relationship to food, bodies, and motherhood, told through interwoven monologues from three generations of women, each alone in her own kitchen yet bound by a shared family recipe. Rena, her daughter Rachel, and her granddaughter Maya reveal how love, scarcity, diet culture, and ethical anxiety are passed down alongside family traditions. When Maya bakes the original buttercake for her own daughter's birthday, she confronts the risk of repeating inherited harm—and the possibility that love, offered imperfectly, might still be enough. *Bittercake* explores how food becomes a language of care, control, and survival across generations.

CHARACTERS:

RENA – Elderly. A post-war immigrant. Warm, practical, and reverent.

RACHEL – Mid to late 50s. Rena's daughter. Polished, anxious. Skinny but not fit.

MAYA – Late 20s. Rachel's daughter. Wry, modern, and emotionally over-processed. Visible tattoos.

TIME: Present day

SETTING: Each character sits in their own kitchen.

ACT ONE

AT RISE:

The three women stand in their respective kitchens.

RENA

I've loved three things in my life: my daughter, my husband, and butter. *(beat.)* Usually in that order.

When I was young, we couldn't afford it. If we were lucky enough to have cream—which we didn't mostly—we made butter ourselves.

Churned it by hand. *(beat.)* Less charming than it sounds, though my daughter would call it "a great arm workout."

RACHEL

(Looking at her arms, flapping the loose skin.) God. I need to work out more. Or maybe accept my body as it is.

Beat.

(Looks at arms some more.) Right. I need to work out more.

RENA

My mother always saved a spoonful for *Shabbos*. She'd hide that butter in the back of the icebox like it was gold. Which to us, it was.

Mmmm...

RENA and RACHEL

Butter...

RACHEL

Could anything be more disgusting? One tablespoon is a hundred calories. A hundred! For that, I could have a glass of Chardonnay. Two, if I run an extra mile at lunch.

RENA and RACHEL

L'chaim...

RENA

...my mother would say, right before she served her famous buttercake. *L'chaim* means, "to life."

"We're in America now," she'd say. "One day, we'll have this every night."

Beat.

We never did. But I carried on the tradition. I make it for my Rachel every year for her special day.

Mmmm...

RENA and MAYA

Buttercake...

MAYA

I don't know how to talk about this without getting canceled. That cake should come with a content warning. At least the butter part. I mean, one cow burps out, what—four hundred liters of methane a day? Got milk? No. Got existential dread? Constantly.

Beat.

I tried to make Grandma's buttercake once in college. But after you remove the butter and eggs (I'm vegan, obvi), and the flour (gluten-free), you're basically left with sugar. And I don't do sugar. I do agave nectar, which is amber so it feels spiritual.

RACHEL

My mother says food is love. "Finish your plate, darling, you're skin and bones!" Then, years later: "You'd be so pretty if you just lost ten pounds." Pick a lane. Please.

Beat.

Or tell me which part was the love.

RENA

Every year, I'd look at my beautiful daughter and think, "How can I give you everything, when I know what the world takes?"

Beat.

I wanted her to have an easier life than mine.

RACHEL

So I keep going. (*beat.*) I make that cake every year. No one eats it but Mama. Still—I make it. It's easier than not.

MAYA

Mom messed with the recipe, too. She got rid of the butter. Fine, good, the planet thanks you. But in its place? Smart Balance. Which, if you don't know, is what happens when scientists ask, "What if we made plastic... spreadable?"

She says it's for her health, but you tell me—does looking like a woman shaped like an apology count as healthy?

Beat.

Yikes. That was mean. Love you, Mom.

Beat.

But why do you need to work out so much? Suffering is cardio enough.

RENA

You can't muscle a cake into being. You cream the butter and sugar carefully, until it's light and fluffy. Like clouds. That's the secret.

RACHEL

The secret to making it light? Applesauce. I learned that from Oprah... or maybe my therapist.

MAYA

My therapist says Mom gave me "food narratives." I said, "Yeah, it's called being a woman, Dr. Green. That'll be two hundred dollars, please."

RENA

When Rachel was born, I made the cake with extra butter. I wanted her to taste abundance. To have the best.

RACHEL

When Maya was born, I was back in my size 2 jeans in six weeks. Everyone said I looked amazing but I couldn't stop shaking. (*beat.*) I wanted my body back.

MAYA

I told myself I'd do it differently with Zola. No "good" foods, "bad" foods. Just food.

Beat.

But "doing it differently" is hard when you don't know what that looks like

RENA

Truth is, I never liked what I looked like. I was strange, foreign, poor. But Rachel, she was gorgeous. *(beat.)* But I was too buddy protecting her to mention it.

RACHEL

I love my daughter, but when she was born, I felt I'd lost something, *(beat.)* And then I hated myself for thinking that.

MAYA

I watch my daughter Zola eat. She's four now. *(beat.)* She stops when she's full. It's like magic. =

RACHEL

But I must have done something right, because she's a wonderful mother herself.

MAYA

I keep waiting for the spell to break. *(beat.)* I hope I don't break it.

RACHEL

Once I let Maya lick the spoon. Just once. She was maybe four. Mama said, "Let the child enjoy!" But doesn't she know this is how it starts?

MAYA

It starts with fear, when a yes becomes a no.

RACHEL

I thought, one lick won't kill her. *(beat.)* Wait, how many calories are in a lick? And then I thought, I need help. But then I thought nothing because I poured myself a Chardonnay.

MAYA

When your mom yanks a spoonful of batter so hard it drips down the wall like yellow tears.

Beat.

She swears it didn't happen. But the body remembers. It's rude like that.

RENA, RACHEL, and MAYA

You spend your whole life trying to fill a hole you never dug.

RENA

Once you've lived through war, your body flinches, even when there's nothing coming.

MAYA

I just put the memory out of my mind. Though it keeps showing up. Totally uninvited.

RACHEL

My mother held Maya for a moment. And when no one was looking, I swiped my finger in the batter and ate it.

MAYA

My daughter turns four today. And I decide—God knows why—to make buttercake. Grandma Rena's recipe. None of my mother's... renovations.

RACHEL

Mom's recipe card is like a Hebrew prayer. I try to follow it, even if I don't know what I'm saying.

MAYA

I stare at the words. Her loopy handwriting looks like an old love letter. Stained with grease.

RENA

A tidy baker makes a tasteless cake, my mother used to say.

MAYA

When I bought the butter—grass-fed of course—I hid them at the checkout like a teenage boy buying tampons. *(beat.)* But the checker didn't blink. Because it's just butter. It's just—

RENA, RACHEL and MAYA

Butter.

MAYA

She probably eats Cheez-wiz and Spam and then just... continues with her day. Doesn't even think about it.

Beat.

Monster. *(beat.)* Lucky monster.

RACHEL

I still make that cake. Every year. For Maya's birthday. No one eats it but Mama. She takes a bite and says, "It's different." And I say, "It's better." And she says nothing. Which is her way of saying everything.

RENA

Rachel says my cake is too rich. She insists on substituting everything but the pan.

But I'm eighty-three. What's butter going to do, kill me? I should be so lucky to have such a delicious death.

MAYA

I cream the butter and sugar until it becomes airy.

RACHEL

My version is far lighter than my mother's. Once, on Maya's sixth birthday, I ate a piece. A real piece. (*beat.*) It tasted like tears.

MAYA

I add one egg. Then the next and the next. I don't think about the carbon footprint or what my body will do with this or what this says about my values or whether my great-great-grandchildren will have a planet.

RACHEL

Is that legacy? Doing something over and over till it breaks your heart?

MAYA

I just make the cake, as if my hands know what to do.

RENA

Like my mother said, "Nothing really disappears. It just changes hands."

MAYA

It rises perfectly. Golden. The whole apartment smells like—

RENA

Home.

RACHEL

Danger.

MAYA

Something that already knew me.

Beat.

Zola runs in. And I see myself at her age. And my mother pulling back. And my grandmother offering more. And my great-grandmother hiding butter like it was hope.

Beat.

Four generations of women and a cake. We've got to get some new material.

RACHEL

I don't know how to stop.

RENA

You keep moving. That's all.

MAYA

What if I don't want to carry this?

RENA

Then it carries you.

MAYA

I start to tell Zola that I'm making an exception. That butter is violence. That methane is murder. That we don't eat this, we don't *do* this. That I love the planet. That I love her more. That this isn't about food, it's about values, it's about control, it's about...

RENA, RACHEL and MAYA

Love?

RACHEL

I remember the spoon. How small her hand was. How fast I pulled it away.

Beat.

I thought I was protecting her.

MAYA

Zola's just standing there. Innocent. Eager.

Beat.

So I cut a piece. A little crooked 'cause my hand is shaking.

I hand her the plate. Hold my breath. Watch her eat.

RENA

My favorite part is seeing the plates licked clean.

MAYA

"This is the best cake ever, Mommy" (*beat.*) And there it is, my grandmother's smile on her little face.

RENA

All I wanted was to give her it all.

RACHEL

All I wanted was to have it all.

MAYA

All I wanted was to be... different. *(beat.)* Spoiler: I'm not.

RENA

My mother used to say, before she served her cake...

RACHEL

Nim, nim.

MAYA

Isn't that Yiddish for eat?

RENA

It means take it.

RACHEL

I always did.

MAYA

I can't take it.

Beat.

Zola looks up from her empty plate and sees a tear rolling down my cheek.

RENA

A little more, darling?

RACHEL

No, thank you. I'm fu— *(beat.)* Actually, yes. Just a smidgeon.

MAYA

She just climbs into my lap. And I hold her. This is all the sweetness I need. My beautiful girl, with all of us in her.

RACHEL

How heavenly.

RENA

And don't forget to make—

MAYA

—A wish.

RENA

To have enough.

RACHEL

To be enough.

MAYA

To heal enough.

RENA, RACHEL and MAYA

(Emphatically) Enough.

Lights fade.

THE END.